



Flushed with color

With its beak tucked under its bright pink wing, a flamingo takes time off from feeding. This wading bird gets its colorful plumage from the food it eats. There are chemical pigments called carotenoids in the microorganisms and shrimp that the flamingo filters from salty lakes. These pigments circulate in the bird's blood until they reach the feather-forming cells in its skin. Here, the pink color is built into new feathers, which grow to replace those that are shed when the flamingo molts.